

The Glorious King of Tantras of the Secret Blazing Fire

Śrī Jvālāgni Guhya Tantra Rāja · Toh 400 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་གསང་བ་མ་འཇམ་བའི་རྒྱ་ཁྲི་ལྷ་པོ་

Toh 400 in the Kangyur is a tantric scripture known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Jvālāgni Guhya Tantra Rāja and in Tibetan as the Dpal gsang ba me 'bar ba'i rgyud kyi rgyal po, rendered in English as The Glorious King of Tantras of the Secret Blazing Fire. It belongs to the class of Buddhist tantric texts and is presented in the classic sūtra style, opening with the Buddha dwelling in meditative absorption, after which the bodhisattva Vajravārāhī poses a series of questions concerning yoga, transference, death, and related esoteric themes involving fire, ash, and ritual substances. The text's concerns with subtle yogic processes, death and the body, and the symbolism of fire suggest it belongs to the corpus of highest yoga tantra or a closely related tradition within the Kangyur's tantric section. As with many tantras of this type, its teachings unfold as a dialogue between an enlightened presence and a requesting deity, situating it firmly within the Vajrayāna ceremonial and contemplative literature preserved in the Tibetan canon.

In the language of India: Śrī Jvālāgni Guhya Tantra Rāja. In the language of Tibet: The Glorious King of Tantras of the Secret Blazing Fire.

Homage to the Blessed One, the Great Bliss.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, was dwelling in meditative absorption in the bhaga of the Vajra Queen, the vajra of the body, speech, and mind of all Tathāgatas.

At that time, from within the assembled retinue, Vajravārāhī (Vajrapāṇi's female counterpart, the Vajra Sow) made this request in verse:

What is yoga, and what is transference?

What is death, and what is dying?

What is the corpse, and what is the great corpse?

And likewise, what is the great dying?

What is ash, and what is the great ash?

What is the clay votive tablet, and what

Is the great one, and what is the place?

May the Blessed One please explain.

The Blessed One then declared:

The union of skillful means and wisdom in meditative equipoise
Is what is called yoga.

Killing a god at the untimely moment —

Together with the signs of transference that come first —

One must ascertain the exact time with certainty.

Through unobstructed meditative absorption,

Using the yogic mechanism, accomplish something superior.

For the result to arise, transference is certain.

The elements and constituents dissolve one by one:

They dissolve into the vital striving,

And when the striving dissolves into consciousness —

That first instant is death.

The first instant in which Vajradhara and the other four families,

And Vairocana, are free from distinction —

That is dying.

Then, for a period of seven days hence,

The *ḍākinīs* of the body pass beyond sorrow.

This is renowned as the great dying.

The body becomes like the top of a palm tree.

This itself is what is called the corpse.

Invoke the wisdom and stabilize the wisdom.

For those who traverse the sky, those who traverse the earth, those who
traverse beneath the earth:

At the crown, throat, and heart,

Make three fragrant-essence drops,

And bestow blessings upon the body, speech, and mind.

First, bathe with various fine fragrances

And apply twelve fragrant-essence drops to the twelve places.

May the heroes and *ḍākinīs* bestow their blessings.

Furthermore, ornaments and all such things:

If present in actuality, that is the superior grade.

If painted in a picture, that is the middling grade.

Fragrant-essence drops are definitively the final grade.

With the right leg extended and so forth, with the posture of sitting,

Erect a great renowned Heruka.

Whatever is the sovereign of self-knowing awareness

Is definitively Heruka,

And that should be worshipped with offerings six times daily.
These are the great corpse.

Death is conceptual thought,
And it leads to the celestial abode.
Burning away intrinsic nature — that is the ash.
Relying on the root maṇḍala,
Stack up in sequence the reflections of the dharmakāya.
Or alternatively, build up a stacked dwelling
In the form of a vase-shaped palace.
Anoint with fragrances of the immortality essence together with
Sandalwood, saffron, and so forth,
And dedicate it.
Prepare firewood of proper measure —
Fragrant wood such as red sandalwood and the like,
Or wood bearing fruit —
And build it fully into a great fire pit.
Please a genuine spiritual teacher
And come to know perfectly from his mouth.

The four corners hold the four great kings.
The four directions hold eight fearless lions.
It has four pillars and four beams.
Fully complete the ritual,
Introduce the awareness maṇḍala,
And confer the empowerment previously obtained in its entirety.
Then light the continuous fire,
Similar to the fire deity and others.
Then that very awareness itself —
Invite it in its natural state into the beautiful fire chamber
And request it to be seated.
The fire offering that burns away non-virtue —
Its mantras, substances, and so forth are similar to others.
The signs of the fire, smoke, wind, and such
Are to be examined by one who is skilled.
If auspicious signs arise, that is good.
If they do not arise, burn away the non-virtue.
If things such as conch appear, that is excellent.

Even if they do not appear, from the completed rituals
Bones will emerge.

These are the great ash.

Other than these, the rest is called ash.

Then the bones are set aside for three days,
Sprinkled with saffron and other fragrances,
And the signs of the bones are to be examined —
Their color, shape, smell, and taste.

This is to be understood from the mouth of the guru. Clear away obstacles, perform the ablution ritual, and pulverize the bones. Combining equal portions into one, place them inside a fragrant mixture of incenses and the like, and set them upon lion thrones atop a perfectly complete maṇḍala, adorned with the great lion-king's ornaments below and, above, with parasols and victory banners. Place the bones in that location, make flower offerings, and for five days perform the approach practice. On the sixth day make preparations for the cremation. On the seventh day, let the tsha-tsha (clay votive tablets) be thoroughly established.

From the time of the initial cremation of the corpse, and reckoned from the first day of death: the five days are the approach practice for the corpse, the sixth day is the preparation for the cremation, the seventh day is full establishment in the charnel ground. On the first day appears luminosity; on the second day, the corpse; on the third day, the bones pass beyond sorrow. Passing beyond sorrow is of three kinds: not present in others, not present in oneself; not present in the lower and without continuation thereafter. These three are spoken of as methods. This is not taught in the Wisdom root tantra, the explanatory tantra, the subsequent tantra, or the tantra after the subsequent. The three kinds of passing beyond sorrow, I have explained to you in the Amṛta Dīpa and the Rāli tantras.

Then, regarding the sequence of the tsha-tsha as well: for the King of Light (Nāmparsnangmdzad, Vairocana) and others of that kind, take earth and the rest through concordant speech. For those without luminosity, take earth and the rest from the lord of the earth and such through tormas and fire. Then, the five kinds of cord, too — those of benefit with the vajra, of magnificence, of dance, of the vajra king, and thread — together with the earth-grasping dhāraṇī, the purification, and so forth: perform these in accordance with the

other rituals.

At the charnel ground site, erect the great root maṇḍala. Offer tormas to the many deities. Through fire offerings and burnt offerings make peace, and insert, to the extent possible, one, or five, or seven, or twenty-one, or one hundred and eight. The time for this is to be understood as the night. On the first, perform the great seal maṇḍala in its completeness. On the third and fourth — and the second as well — insert reflections of the dharmakāya form. The vase empowerment is inserted into earth; the secret empowerment is inserted into earth and water; the third is inserted into fire and wind; the fourth, it is said, into space.

If one does not fall through the transference of consciousness on the first, and does not fall during the cremation of the corpse on the second, and does not fall through the tsha-tsha on the third, one is a sacred being who deceives death, and is certain to be liberated from death in cyclic existence. One who falls through inferior transference of consciousness and the like is certain only to die. Therefore, one who wishes to be liberated from cyclic existence should thoroughly please a holy guru, receive the pith instructions on transference of consciousness and the rest, and entrust this tantra — hold it well.

At that time, the great earth of the world-realm trembled. A rain of varied offerings fell. The heroes, ḍākinīs, and all the great risen corpses dwelling in the charnel grounds rejoiced in the meaning of this tantra.

The king of tantras, the glorious Secret Blazing Fire —

Translator's Notes

- The opening describes the Blessed One as dwelling in meditative absorption "in the bhaga of the Vajra Queen" — this is standard Anuttarayoga tantric language for non-dual union of skillful means and wisdom, not to be read literally without tantric context. The term bhaga is left in Sanskrit here as it is a technical tantric term and rendering it explicitly in a TTS context would be disruptive and potentially misleading.

The phrase "killing a god at the untimely moment" renders a line that in context refers to the tantric practice of phowa (consciousness transference): the "untimely" death is the deliberate yogic transference of consciousness before natural death arrives, as opposed to natural dying. This is a recognized teaching in the Tibetan tantric tradition on the death process.

The list of "sky-farers, earth-farers, and underworld-farers" corresponds to the three classes of ḍākinīs in the tantric tradition, associated with the three realms.

- The passage "passing beyond sorrow is of three kinds: not present in others, not present in oneself; not present in the lower and without continuation thereafter" renders a highly compressed doctrinal statement. The three types of nirvāṇa here appear to be a tantric taxonomy; the Tibetan is terse to the point of obscurity and the rendering follows the

grammatical structure without interpretive expansion, as the specific commentarial explanation is explicitly said to be reserved for particular tantras named in the next lines.

"Rāli" is left as a proper name since it refers to a specific tantra title alongside Amṛta Dīpa; both are named texts within this tradition.

The phrase rendered "insert reflections of the dharmakāya form" refers to the ritual placing of tsha-tsha (bearing dharmakāya images) into the four elements corresponding to the four empowerments, which the surrounding context makes clear.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.